intelligence machinery, upgrading the police forces, and better inter-state coordination.[27] That the various UN resolutions were making little impact and that most Western countries (and also China) were openly engaging with the Taliban was left unsaid. In reality, the one multilateral forum that did have limited impact on the Afghan political situation which was the six plus two (6+2), did not allow India entry. Comprising of Iran, China, Pakistan, Uzbekistan, Tajikistan, and Turkmenistan as core members, it had the US and Russia as the 'plus two'.

From the Taliban's side there was no dedicated team of negotiators at this forum, but Mullah Omar chose various officials to represent its interests. These included Mullah Mohammad Hasan (former governor of Kandahar), Mullah Mohammad Rabbani, Wakil Ahmad Muttawakil (foreign minister), Abdul Karim Zahid (deputy foreign minister), Amir Khan Muttaqi (representing the Kandahari leadership and close aide to Mullah Omar).[28] Yunus Qanooni and Abdullah were representing the UF at the six plus two. Created on Uzbek president Islam Karimov's initiative, and baptised by the UN, the process emerged from the Tashkent Declaration in 1999 and its first official meeting took place on 14 January 1999. Titled *On Fundamental Principles for a peaceful Settlement of the Conflict in Afghanistan*, the declaration had prompted a UNSC Presidential Statement SC/6743 condemning the Taliban for 'undermining international efforts to facilitate the restoration of peace in Afghanistan'.[29]

For the then UN Secretary-General, Kofi Annan, the six plus two was an essential forum to broker a peaceful resolution, especially in context of Mazar-e-Sharif's fall and the murder of eleven Iranian diplomats in August 1998.[30] In retaliation, Tehran had mobilised 70,000 troops on the Afghan border, only to be restrained by the UN.[31] That same month, as part of 'Operation Infinite Reach', US President Bill Clinton ordered cruise missile strikes in Afghanistan and Sudan in response to the bombing of US Embassies in Kenya and Tanzania by Al Qaeda.[32] Failing to assassinate its key target Osama bin Laden, the seventy-five cruise missiles ended up destroying, among much else, the Muawai militant training camp run by the ISI to train anti-India outfit Harkat-ul-Ansar's cadre.[33] The strikes came after Washington's failed attempts to extradite bin Laden from the Taliban. These developments were critical in changing US belief systems as it